

SOLDIERS OF freedom

DECOLONIZATION

Decolonization after World War II resulted in some three dozen countries in Asia and Africa gaining autonomy from their colonial rulers. In many cases, this newfound independence came after a long struggle and a history of resistance against Western rule, including uprisings such as the 1857 rebellion in India (see pp. 156–157) or the 1929 Women's War in Nigeria (see pp. 226–227). The decolonization process was different in each country affected, and its impact on women was not uniform. Although typically led by men, women participated in nationalist movements across Asia and Africa in many capacities, and argued that political and legal gender equality should form part of the postcolonial settlements.

Politics and protest

Women were active as revolutionaries before and after independence, although some colonial regimes restricted women's political mobilization, meaning that such participation was more limited or covert. Anticolonial feeling among women was often given added impetus by the failure of the colonial powers to recognize women's concerns. Existing women's groups took up the nationalist cause and new women's organizations, such as the Sierra Leone Women's Movement in 1951, were formed at national and local levels and within political parties. In this way, women became more active in politics and protest, paving the way for gender equality in future

◀ Minority report

Mrs. Renner, a barrister from Lagos, Nigeria, attends the fifth Pan-African Congress in Manchester, England, in 1945 to advocate higher standards of education for African women.

